



BEFORE

Based at Cairo, Illinois, Union land and naval forces were well placed to invade Confederate territory along three rivers—the Mississippi, Tennessee, and Cumberland.

AMPHIBIOUS OFFENSIVE

The prelude to river operations was the **building of seven ironclads** (see [Island Number Ten](#)), completed in January 1862, to create the **Western Gunboat Flotilla**. Union General **Henry W. Halleck** still hesitated to take action, but his subordinate **Brigadier General Ulysses S. Grant** was **more eager to fight**. Grant, who had made an **amphibious sortie** against **Belmont** on the Mississippi in November 1861, now proposed an **attack on Fort Henry** on the Tennessee.

The decision to attack Fort Henry was made at the end of January 1862. Built the previous year, the fort was poorly sited and unlikely to be able to withstand infantry assault or naval gunfire for very long. The attack was to be a joint operation by two army divisions under General Grant—some 15,000 men—and a flotilla under Commander Andrew H. Foote, comprising four of the new City-class ironclads and three timberclads (with timber, rather than iron, armor). The two commanders were contrasting characters, Grant a down-to-earth man with a reputation for drinking, Foote a high-minded teetotaler. But they formed a harmonious team, good relations aided by Grant's acceptance that reducing the fort would be a matter for the gunboats.

Fall of Fort Henry

Steaming down the Tennessee on February 5, the gunboats and troop transports encountered mines, but these caused no damage. The troops landed several miles from Fort Henry and were still struggling to reach their objective across difficult terrain when, on February 6, Foote opened the naval attack. Most of the Confederates swiftly left for Fort Donelson, 12 miles (19km) away on the Cumberland River. Artillerymen remained with their guns, but after two hours the defenders of the wrecked fort surrendered.

Confederate General Albert Sidney Johnston, commander of the Western Military Department, now had to decide whether to attempt a defense of Fort Donelson and with what strength. When Fort Henry fell, he withdrew his forces from Kentucky to Nashville,